

WORKING TEMPLATE

The Networking Meeting

A 20-minute template you can run — and complete with AI — for every coffee, call, and connection.

Curated by Snack (Jack Kruse)

Shared via Mahan · usemahan.com

Adapted from the framework in The 20-Minute Networking Meeting by Nathan A. Perez & Marcia Ballinger.

How to use this.

THE WORKFLOW

Download this template and drop it into the AI system of your choice. Then download a PDF of your contact's LinkedIn profile and prompt the AI to complete the template — especially the tailored discussion questions. That gives you a strong starting point to tweak.

As always: the product you get is only as good as the context you put into the prompt.

Use a reputable AI tool, and don't paste anything sensitive — treat a contact's profile the way you'd want your own handled.

COPY-PASTE PROMPT

"You are helping me prepare for a 20-minute networking meeting. I've attached the LinkedIn profile of [Name], who is [role] at [company]. Using the attached profile and any public information, complete this template. For the discussion section, draft 3 specific, insightful questions — each built on a concrete observation about their background, company, or industry (recent news, a role change, a company milestone). Avoid anything I could answer with basic research, or that asks them to recite their background. Keep my objective in mind: [your objective]."

Use it as a starting point, not a script — the AI's draft is a brainstorming piece to sharpen in your own voice, not something to read verbatim. Tighten it, cut what doesn't sound like you, and keep the judgment yours. The last thing you want is to come across as wholly reliant on AI; the point is simply to get off a blank page faster.

Contact name:

Current role & sector:

Date:

Objective:

Step	Phase	Time	Purpose
1	Great First Impression	2–3 min	Gratitude and chit-chat
2	Great Overview	~1 min	Overview of your experience
3	Great Discussion	12–15 min	5 key questions
4	Great Ending	2 min	Thanks and wrap-up
5	Great Follow-Up	Immediate	Meaningful note within 24 hours

1 Great First Impression

2–3 minutes · chit-chat

- **Gratitude and connection.** Thank them for sharing their valuable time. Remind them how you connected and note any common ground.
- **Lay out the agenda.** You are the captain of this meeting — you run it, not them. Emphasize the 20-minute timeline.

2 Great Overview

~60 seconds · your elevator pitch

- **Cut the military acronyms.** This one minute needs the most reflection, repetition, and review.
- Tailor and tweak it for every meeting.
- Use resources like [Best Military Resume](#) to help translate your experience.

3 Great Discussion

12–15 minutes · 5 key questions, each an observation + a question

Structure — Your 5 questions = 3 you research and tailor (let the AI draft these from their LinkedIn profile) + the 2 standard closers below.

Example — observation + question: "I saw [firm] just stood up a new [division] — how has that changed what your team actually prioritizes day to day?" (An observation they can tell you built research, paired with a question only they can answer.)

- Do your research — never ask a question research could already answer. Those precious minutes are too valuable to spend on what a website could tell you.
- Don't ask them to walk through their background. Don't ask for a resume review or a job. Don't ask personal questions unless it's obviously appropriate.
- Know the industry — its latest trends and challenges. Always visit the company website.
- There's a difference between "so, what do you do?" and "what's it like — what does a typical day look like?"
- Search terms to prep with: recent events, press releases, key customers, new products, milestones, pending deals.
- **The goal:** gain specific knowledge or insight based on the contact's experience.

Standard closer 1 — the referral ask. "Could you think of anyone else — veteran or otherwise — working or teaching at [org] who'd be useful for me to connect with?"

This may feel uncomfortable, but it's 100% expected. As long as you didn't blow the earlier part of the meeting, they'll be glad to do it — but you have to ask. Be specific and lead their thinking to help them.

Standard closer 2 — offer value. "How can I help you — in your current role or another professional venture?"

A junior-to-senior "how can I help" can ring hollow — so make it concrete. Offer a real lane: a veteran's perspective, an introduction you can actually make, or simply being a reliable point of contact. If they still can't name anything, a small token geared to something they care about goes a long way.

4 Great Ending

2 minutes · wrap up well

- Review action items, hit the highlights, and express gratitude.
- Note any follow-on touchpoints.

5 Great Follow-Up

within 24 hours

- **Keep track of everything** — your notes are invaluable. Handwritten, or AI-generated via tools like Fireflies, Zoom, or Google Meet.
- A handwritten note is always preferred and will set you apart. At a minimum, send an email.
- Always send a note of gratitude to the person who connected or referred you.
- **Ongoing contact — every 90 days is the goal.** Follow up with an article or resource they'd genuinely value (easy on LinkedIn with a tagged comment), or when your contact info or employment status changes. Every few weeks is too often and comes off strange.

Why I built Mahan — keeping track of every one of these is exactly what led me to build the Mahan networking app. My notes from every meeting live in a linked doc inside the app, and every Sunday I get a targeted AI digest that grades my meetings against my long-term goals. The 90-day cadence is a built-in feature.

6 Meeting Log

capture it while it's fresh

Key takeaways	Commitments I made	Referrals / intros	Next touch (≤90d)

CREDITS

This template adapts the networking framework from The 20-Minute Networking Meeting by Nathan A. Perez and Marcia Ballinger, PhD (Career Innovations Press). It is an independent adaptation and is not affiliated with or endorsed by the authors or publisher.